



(LEFT) VARADARAJAN'S FUNERAL PROCESSION; (BELOW) HIS GRIEVING WIFE SARASWATHI



Photographs by GAVASKAR S

put to vote a resolution calling for action against him. A voice vote stripped him of all elected posts—and dignity.

Though he was battling marital discord for more than a decade, nobody imagined that Varadarajan would take this harsh decision. His final story dips in and out of four lives—U. Vasuki, Central Committee member, his friend Pramila, his wife Saraswathi, a Dalit divorcee who he married “under instructions and blessings of the party”, and Jhansi Rani, a state committee member. Vasuki, Saraswathi and Rani filed different complaints against him and the party constituted a commission to look into the charges. The commission came to the conclusion that Varadarajan had committed “the offence of sending offensive and inappropriate SMS messages to a woman”.

AFTER THE LAST ELECTORAL DEBACLE, THE CPI(M) WENT ON A “RECTIFICATION CAMPAIGN” THAT IMPOSED MORALITY CHECKS ON ITS MEMBERS.

Vasuki, who spearheaded the campaign against Varadarajan, belongs to the first family of the CPI(M) in Tamil Nadu as her parents were both Central Committee members. She allegedly led a faction in the party which is against Varadarajan. His rapid growth in the party hierarchy had them seething in rage. After the conspiracy was allegedly hatched against him and the Central Committee took note of the complaints, Varadarajan shot off a letter to the party boss, saying he was not being given a fair deal. “That

punishment ought to be proportionate to misconduct may be dismissed as a bourgeois concept, but my punishment is grossly unjust and severe,” he wrote.

Not without reason. There was no formal complaint from Pramila to whom he had allegedly sent SMS messages. “Here I must state that Pramila is not a teenaged girl, who would be scared at the very mention of writing a complaint. She dared to lodge a written complaint against a DMK legislator for cheating her after sexually abusing on her promise of marriage,” Varadarajan wrote to Karat. In her complaint, Rani alleged that Varadarajan had told Pramila of his desire to marry her. Vasuki’s complaint is silent on this allegation. Varadarajan also alleged that both Vasuki and Rani were keen on assuaging the agitated feelings of Saraswathi and in the process attempting “a barter deal” of dropping of her divorce threat with disciplinary action against him.

Varadarajan’s death has evoked deep outrage across a wide cross section of the party and highlighted the dwindling image and Orwellian ways of the central leadership which, after providing to be a disaster in the

world of realpolitik, is desperate to cage the private lives of the Comrades. Soon after the electoral debacle last year, the party went on a rectification campaign with severe morality checks on its members “to purge craving for sensual pleasures”, misplacing its priorities. After scripting the document, trouble has been Karat’s constant travelling companion. Dr K.S. Manoj, a former CPI(M) MP from Kerala, recently quit the party in protest against the “rectification document” that directed party members not to participate in religious ceremonies.